cavalrymen expected of him as a mansabdar of 20. In time, as men were found unable, or unwilling, to supply the actual number of horses and men, Akbar would institute the double rank system (sawar and zat). But for Badauni, at this time, asking for a fixed salary was a mistake as promotions were much more certain for talented men by rising through the military ranks, protected from the interference of the clergy. Badauni was scrambling now to remedy his earlier foolish miscalculations. ‘Why, he has just been appointed one of the court imams,’ grumbled Akbar when presented with Badauni’s request, ‘how can he go?’ Finally, Badauni persuaded Akbar that he wanted to ‘dye his beard in blood’ for the sake of the Padshah, apparently immune to the irony of fighting jihad under a Hindu general. On 3 April 1576, the Mughal army of 5,000 chosen men marched out from Ajmer to Gogunda.

While the Mughal army camped at Mandalgarh for two months, gathering their forces, Rana Pratap was at Gogunda calculating the Mughal strength and rallying his men. It is estimated that he had ‘3000 horsemen, 2000 infantry, 100 elephants and 100 miscellaneous men who served as drummers, trumpeters and pick-men’. The rana’s warriors included Bhil tribesmen, forest dwellers who grew up stalking prey on silent footsteps and learning the spiky topography of the Mewar landscape while hunting deer, wild boars, hyenas, jackals, hares, and bears with their bows and arrows. The rana moved the bulk of his men to the village of Khamnor, at the entrance of a narrow, ravine-like pass called Haldighati with shifting sands the colour of turmeric gold. According to James Tod, ‘above and below, the Rajputs were posted, and on the cliffs and pinnacles overlooking the field of battle the faithful aborigines, the Bhils with their natural weapon, the bow and arrow, and huge stones ready to roll upon the combatant enemy’.

On a blazing day in June, Rana Pratap decided to launch an attack when he saw the Mughal forces dragging their great artillery guns across the river Banas, depleted after the relentless summer. In retaliation, Man Singh sent an advance guard of 900 skirmishers under Syed Hashim Baraha who, it was said, fought with determined gallantry. The Sayyids of Baraha were a group that had been traditionally considered somewhat rustic and boorish but who were courted and greatly valued by Akbar, who gave them the coveted and honoured position in the Mughal vanguard. Jahangir would describe them later as ‘the bravest men of their time’. Skirmishers or shamsherbaz (gladiators), were specialized troops in the Mughal army, elite